

▲ **The murder** of Archduke Franz Ferdinand while in a carriage as depicted in this magazine illustration, steadily impelled countries to take sides with either the Axis or Allied powers.

On 28 June 1914, a Bosnian Serb, Gavrilo Princip, assassinated Austrian Archduke Franz Ferdinand and his wife Sophie in Sarajevo, Serbia. A month later, Austria-Hungary declared war on Serbia, shaking up Europe and splitting it into warring factions. World War I pitted the Central Powers, which included Germany, Austria-Hungary, Turkey, and Bulgaria against Britain, France, Russia, Italy, Serbia, and later the United States of America, who together formed the Allies.

This “war to end all wars” saw the British mobilize India’s resources in service to the Empire in an unprecedented manner. The colony served as a vast reservoir from which large and sustained unilateral transfers of men, money, and material were made. In a telegram sent in April 1918 to Lord Chelmsford, the Viceroy of India (1916–21), British Prime Minister David Lloyd George (1916–22), wrote: “The future course of the war ... depends on our ability to refit our armies as fast as we can ... you should take this opportunity to do everything in your power to increase Indian establishment for war, not only in troops, but in railway materials and military equipments of all kinds ... ”